

UNIT 2

Integrity Systems of Rwanda

Comprehensive Summary

Covering All Headings and Sub-Sections

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2.1 The Concept of Integrity

Integrity, derived from the Latin word *integer* (meaning 'whole'), refers to the practice of being consistently honest and adhering uncompromisingly to strong moral and ethical principles. It involves aligning one's values with one's actions at all times, regardless of circumstance. Key qualities associated with integrity include consistency, honesty, truthfulness, accountability, impartiality, and incorruptibility.

A person of integrity behaves the same way whether or not anyone is watching, and does not separate their personal, professional, or social identity — they are one unified, authentic self. Integrity stands in opposition to hypocrisy: when you are 'whole' and consistent, you bring the same YOU to every situation.

All definitions of integrity contain two core elements:

- What is right — ethical values, moral principles, and wisdom.
- What you do — your actions and behaviours.

Integrity is having the inner personal strength and courage to always link these two elements, even in difficult situations or when no advantage is gained from doing so.

2.1.1 Consistency

Consistency means behaving the same way regardless of mood, pressure, or circumstance. A person of integrity does not allow personal conflicts or fluctuating emotions to alter their conduct or decision-making from one situation to the next. If you just had an argument before walking into a meeting, consistency means making a conscious choice to release the negativity and not carry it forward.

2.1.2 Honesty or Accuracy

Honesty means that one's words, behaviours, and actions truthfully reflect one's stated values. A leader who claims to value teamwork but dismisses others' input, or who professes love for colleagues while publicly humiliating junior employees, lacks honesty and therefore lacks integrity. Being in integrity requires authenticity — saying what you mean and doing what you say.

2.2 Types of Integrity Violations

Integrity violations are breaches of moral values and norms accepted by an organization or society. Common violations include:

- Corruption — bribery, nepotism, cronyism, and patronage.
- Fraud and theft, including manipulation of information to cover up misconduct.
- Waste and abuse of organizational resources, including time and property.
- Conflict of interest through gifts, promises, discounts, or outside employment.
- Misuse of power or improper use of authority toward citizens.

- Abuse, manipulation, or unauthorized disclosure of confidential information.
- Inappropriate treatment of others — discrimination, intimidation, harassment.
- Private-time misconduct such as domestic violence or substance abuse.
- Falsification of reports, policy documents, or expense claims.
- Bullying, gossiping, or isolating individuals in the workplace.
- Unauthorized use of colleagues' passwords or access codes.

2.2.1 Types of Academic Integrity Violations

Academic integrity violations take many forms. The main categories are:

Plagiarism

Using another person's words, ideas, data, or images as if they were one's own, without proper attribution. This includes direct copying, paraphrasing without citation, and using non-textual materials without credit.

Cheating

Using or possessing prohibited materials or unauthorized assistance during academic exercises. Examples include:

- Prohibited collaboration on individual assignments.
- Copying another student's answers during examinations.
- Submitting purchased or downloaded papers as one's own work.
- Using unauthorized devices or materials during quizzes or exams.

Fabrication

Inventing or falsifying sources, citations, data, or results. Examples include citing non-existent sources, making up experimental data, falsifying patient records, or providing forged excuse documents.

Facilitation of Dishonesty

Deliberately or carelessly allowing one's work to be used by others without permission, or aiding others in violating academic integrity. A facilitator can face the same sanctions as the primary violator.

Academic Sabotage

Deliberately impeding another student's academic progress — for example, destroying their work, defacing library materials, altering their computer files, or preventing their access to learning resources.

Violation of Research or Professional Ethics

Breaching ethical codes specific to a profession or the ethical requirements for acquiring, analyzing, and reporting research data, including misuse of grant funds or violation of duties as a Teaching or Graduate Assistant.

Violations Involving Potentially Criminal Activity

Theft, fraud, forgery, or distribution of illicitly obtained materials — such as selling or buying examinations, forging grade forms, or falsifying university transcripts.

Technological Misconduct

Unauthorized use of computing accounts, sharing passwords, attempting to gain unauthorized access to systems, violating software license agreements, or monitoring another user's data without permission.

Additional Violations

- Facilitating academic integrity violations — helping another engage in dishonesty.
- Classroom misconduct — significantly disrupting the learning environment.
- Unethical or hazardous behaviour during professional experience activities such as internships or practicum placements.

2.3 Forms of Integrity

Internal Integrity

Doing the right thing even when no one is watching and even when no credit will be received for doing so. It is motivated purely by personal values and moral conviction, regardless of external observation.

External Integrity

The visible consistency between one's thoughts, words, and actions as observed by others. High external integrity means what you say and what you do are aligned. A disconnect between stated values and observable actions indicates a lack of external integrity.

Image Integrity

Ensuring that none of one's actions or words can be misinterpreted or misunderstood. Image integrity goes beyond simply acting well — it requires that the impression one leaves on others is accurate and cannot be construed negatively.

2.4 Some Concepts Related to Integrity

Ethics and Integrity

Ethics is a system of values and norms commonly accepted in a society or profession as right. A person of integrity holds values consistent with ethics and behaves accordingly. Integrity is complicated because a person may sincerely believe they are doing right, while others regard those values as wrong — making ethical reflection critical.

Human Rights and Integrity

Human rights relate to integrity in two ways: firstly, rights such as the right to life, fair treatment, and equality are universal values that should guide everyone's conduct. Secondly, human rights

are embedded in international and national law, and respecting the law is a fundamental behavioral characteristic of a person with integrity.

Corruption and Integrity

Corruption — the abuse of public office for private gain — is one specific type of integrity violation and a direct manifestation of its absence. It includes bribery, embezzlement, and other forms of misconduct where individuals exploit their positions for personal benefit at public expense.

Honesty and Integrity

Honesty — the quality of not lying, cheating, or stealing, and of being trustworthy and fair — is one of the foundational values of integrity. A person of integrity must value honesty and consistently behave in an honest manner in all dealings.

Integrity Systems

Integrity systems are the combined result of all organizations, legislation, and initiatives that uphold the integrity of social governance and prevent integrity violations. They operate at both national and international levels, forming a web of accountability and ethical enforcement.

International Integrity Systems

The United Nations

The UN General Assembly adopted the United Nations Convention against Corruption in 2003 — the only legally binding universal anti-corruption instrument. It covers five areas: preventive measures, criminalization and law enforcement, international cooperation, asset recovery, and technical assistance. The UN also adopted an International Code of Conduct for Public Officials in 1996, emphasizing:

- Loyalty to the public interest over personal or political interests.
- Efficient, effective, and integrity-driven performance of public duties.
- Impartiality and fairness in all official functions and relations with the public.

The World Bank and IMF

The World Bank and International Monetary Fund have made corruption prevention central to decisions about development aid and debt relief. Corruption is identified as a major obstacle to economic and social development. The World Bank's anti-corruption strategy is built on five key elements:

- Increasing political accountability.
- Strengthening civil society participation.
- Creating a competitive private sector.
- Mandating institutional restraints on power.
- Improving public sector management.

National Integrity Systems (NIS)

Developed by Transparency International, the National Integrity System model offers a comprehensive framework for fighting corruption and safeguarding integrity at the country level. It is built on:

- Foundations of public awareness and societal values — the base that supports all institutions.
- Pillars — the key institutions and activities that operationalize integrity.
- Goals — sustainable development, government under the rule of law, and quality of life.

The pillars of the NIS include:

- Political will to fight corruption.
- An active parliament to sustain good governance.
- An auditor general as financial watchdog.
- An attorney general as guardian of the public interest.

- A professional public service protecting decision-making.
- The judiciary and rule of law.
- An ombudsman.
- Independent anti-corruption agencies.
- Transparent procurement and financial management procedures.
- A law-abiding private sector.
- Free and independent media.
- Active civil society.
- Supportive international organizations.

Pillars need not be of equal strength — a proactive anti-corruption agency can compensate for weak investigative journalism, for example. The key criterion for evaluating a NIS is completeness: are all pillars and elements present and functioning?

Integrity Systems in Rwanda

Rwanda has constructed a multi-institutional integrity system combining strong political will, legislative frameworks, specialized institutions, and civic culture to promote transparency and accountability — particularly significant given the country's history of genocide and poor governance before 1994.

Foundational Context: Political Will and Zero-Tolerance Policy

Rwanda's integrity system is anchored in top-level government commitment. The ruling RPF has embedded anti-corruption as a core national development priority, framing it as essential for national security and economic growth. This zero-tolerance stance creates an environment where anti-corruption mandates are consistently acted upon.

Key Institutions: Four Pillars of Integrity

Pillar 1 — Prevention and Advocacy

Office of the Ombudsman (Umuvunyi)

Constitutionally mandated to promote justice, good governance, and the eradication of corruption, the Ombudsman's key responsibilities include:

- Asset Declaration — managing a system where public officials declare assets upon assuming, during, and upon leaving office.
- Conflict of Interest — investigating and ruling on potential abuses of power.
- Public Education — leading national integrity campaigns and establishing Integrity Clubs in schools.
- Whistleblower Protection — protecting individuals who report corruption.

Civil Society

Civil society organizations (CSOs) function as complementary partners in promoting integrity, albeit within a strongly state-directed environment. Their roles include:

- Conducting anti-corruption awareness campaigns and social auditing of public projects.
- Providing legal aid and monitoring judicial processes for fairness.
- Advocating for open data and government transparency.
- Participating in national dialogues such as Umwiherero and sector consultations.

Key actors include Transparency International Rwanda (TI-RW), the Legal Aid Forum, the Rwanda Civil Society Platform (RCSP), and research institutes such as IRDP.

Pillar 2 — Detection and Investigation

Rwanda Investigation Bureau (RIB)

Rwanda's primary civilian investigative agency, the RIB investigates all categories of crime including corruption, fraud, cybercrime, and gender-based violence. Key functions include:

- Criminal investigation — securing crime scenes, collecting evidence, and conducting forensic analysis.
- Arrests, detention, and interrogation of suspects.
- Prosecution of minor offences; referral of major cases to the NPPA.
- Crime prevention through public education and community engagement.
- Issuance of Certificates of Good Conduct and investigation of civil matters.

Office of the Auditor General (OAG)

As Rwanda's Supreme Audit Institution, the OAG independently oversees the management of public funds. Its core functions are:

- Financial Audits — verifying the accuracy and fairness of public entities' financial statements.
- Performance Audits — assessing the economy, efficiency, and effectiveness of resource use.
- Compliance Audits — checking adherence to laws, regulations, and parliamentary budgets.
- IT Audits — reviewing the security and integrity of government digital systems.
- Forensic/Investigative Audits — examining specific allegations of fraud or misuse of funds.

The OAG reports directly to Parliament, where the Public Accounts Committee holds public officials accountable in often televised hearings.

Pillar 3 — Prosecution and Sanction

National Public Prosecution Authority (NPPA)

An independent constitutional body led by the Prosecutor General, the NPPA is responsible for prosecuting criminal cases nationwide. Key functions include:

- Initiating prosecutions and representing the state in all courts.
- Directing and supervising RIB investigations.
- Using mediation (Abunzi) and plea bargaining to manage caseloads and promote restorative justice.
- Operating specialized units for corruption, gender-based violence, child protection, and genocide ideology.

- International cooperation on extradition, evidence sharing, and cross-border crime.

The Judiciary

Rwanda's judiciary operates a four-tier court structure:

- Primary Courts — first instance for misdemeanors, small civil claims, and mediation through Abunzi committees.
- Intermediate Courts — original jurisdiction for felonies; appellate jurisdiction from Primary Courts.
- High Court — handles serious crimes, major civil matters, and supervises lower courts; hosts specialized Commercial Courts.
- Supreme Court — final court of appeal; constitutional review; oversight of the entire judiciary.

Specialized tribunals include Military Courts and the now-concluded Gacaca Courts, which processed over 1.9 million genocide-related cases between 2001 and 2012.

Pillar 4 — Oversight and Civic Engagement

The Senate

The Upper Chamber of Parliament, composed of 26 senators serving eight-year terms, focuses on stability, expertise, and constitutional integrity. Key roles include:

- Legislative — reviewing and amending bills from the Chamber of Deputies; initiating legislation.
- Oversight — monitoring the executive, judiciary, and national independent bodies.
- Constitutional — interpreting and amending the constitution; approving key national appointments including the Prosecutor General, Auditor General, Ombudsman, and Supreme Court judges.
- Investigative — setting up special committees to investigate matters of national importance.

Chamber of Deputies

The Lower Chamber, composed of 80 members including women, youth, and disability representatives, is the primary legislative and oversight body. Its core functions are:

- Legislative — drafting, deliberating, amending, and passing laws.
- Oversight — approving the government program, questioning ministers, conducting parliamentary inquiries, and approving the national budget.
- Representational — channelling citizens' concerns and the voices of specific groups into national policy.

Mechanisms of Promoting Integrity

Education as a Mechanism

Education instills social norms such as honesty, fairness, accountability, and transparency from a young age. Schools and universities prepare the youth for future adulthood integrity. Rwanda applies the proverb *igiti kigororwa kikiri gito* (a tree is straightened while it is still young) by training young elites in integrity before they assume major public roles, through formal, non-formal, and informal education pathways. The University of Rwanda plays a critical role in shaping future leaders across all sectors.

Institutional Mechanisms

Institutions promote integrity by limiting individuals' self-interests through:

- Organizational mottos, visions, missions, and values aligned with transparency, social justice, and anti-corruption (e.g., City of Kigali's *umurimo unoze*).
- Establishing justice systems and fighting the culture of impunity — a functioning justice system is one of the key drivers of integrity at all levels of society.

General Conclusion

Integrity refers to building a society free from corruption and other human rights violations, populated by honest people who consistently respect ethics and human rights. Having integrity means living in accordance with your deepest values, being honest with everyone, and always keeping your word.

Rwanda's integrity system demonstrates the power of a coherent, institutionally-driven approach: clear roles among prevention and advocacy (Ombudsman, civil society), detection and investigation (RIB, OAG), prosecution and sanction (NPPA, Judiciary), and oversight and civic engagement (Senate, Chamber of Deputies) create a reinforcing cycle of accountability.

For students, the question is clear: where do we see ourselves in this process? The pursuit of integrity begins now — in the classroom, in academic work, and in every choice made when no one is watching.